



IT2100 – Employability Skills Development

Year 3 Semester 2

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1. Evidence-Based Self-Reflection & Lecture Impact Analysis

Real Incident: Front-End Breakdown – Web Development Module (Year 2, Semester1)

During the Web Development module in my second year, our team of four was assigned to build a fully responsive e-commerce website over a six-week sprint. The project required a functional product listing page, a shopping cart with session persistence, and a user authentication flow. Two weeks before the final submission, I discovered that the teammate responsible for implementing the cart and authentication components had not pushed any working code to our shared GitHub repository. When I brought this up in our weekly stand-up, the situation quickly became uncomfortable: the team member claimed the features were “almost done” while our module lecturer had already set an interim demo for the following Friday.

I arranged an emergency pair-programming session with the struggling teammate on the weekend. By the second day, it was clear that both the cart logic and the login functionality were far from complete. I made the decision to take over those components myself, implementing the shopping cart using JavaScript localStorage and building the authentication flow with a PHP session-based backend — a server-side approach I had only briefly touched in a self-study tutorial. I maintained a running changelog in our shared Google Doc throughout, ensuring the rest of the team could continue working on the product listing and styling without losing direction. We delivered a working demo at the interim review, and our final submission received a high distinction.

This incident shows that I can step in decisively when a team is at risk and adapt technically under pressure. But it also exposed a meaningful gap in my professional behaviour: I had been aware the teammate was struggling for nearly two weeks before I raised it formally, largely because I did not want to create conflict or embarrass them. In a workplace setting, that delay could have missed a client deadline. This tells me I am partially employment-ready in crisis management, but I need to build more proactive communication habits — especially the habit of flagging risks early rather than waiting until they become emergencies.

Self-Assessment Ratings (1–5)

Competency	Rating	Evidence	Behavioural Risk if I Join a Company Tomorrow
Accountability	4/5	In the Web Development project, when the cart and authentication features were at risk, I openly committed to rebuilding them within 48 hours and delivered without blaming the other team member.	I may over-commit and absorb tasks that should be delegated, creating a single point of failure in the team.
Communication	3/5	During the Web Development module presentation, I explained the technical architecture clearly in the written report but struggled to articulate my implementation decisions confidently under live questioning from the lecturer.	I may under-communicate blockers verbally, especially in client-facing meetings, which could lead to misaligned expectations.
Teamwork	4/5	I coordinated the four-person Web Development team using GitHub Projects, held daily async check-ins via WhatsApp, and ensured no team member's feature branch was blocked for more than a day.	I tend to take a dominant coordination role; in a flat team structure, this could come across as micromanagement.
Adaptability	4/5	I self-taught PHP session management and localStorage-based cart logic over one weekend when the original plan failed mid-sprint, implementing both features within 48 hours using official documentation and MDN Web Docs.	When forced to change direction, I sometimes spend too long self-researching before asking for help, which can slow the team down.
Professional Discipline	3/5	During my FYP progress meetings, I consistently submitted weekly progress logs on time, but I missed one supervisor check-in because I misjudged the time required for a data-model revision.	Underestimating task duration is my most likely professional risk; I may promise deliverables based on optimistic estimates rather than adding buffer time.

Lecture Reflection: The “Professional Identity” Lecture

The idea from this module that resonated most strongly with me was the concept discussed in the lecture on Professional Identity: the distinction between being competent and being perceived as professional. The lecturer made the point that technical skill is the floor, not the ceiling, of employability — employers assume you have a degree-level technical ability; what differentiates candidates is how reliably and visibly they demonstrate professional behaviour.

This challenged my thinking significantly. I had always assumed that doing good technical work was sufficient for career progress. Reflecting on the Web Development incident, I realised I had solved the technical problem effectively, but I had not communicated the risk to the team early enough, and I never formally updated my lecturer on the issue until the interim demo was already underway. My professional visibility was lower than my actual contribution warranted. This idea has made me more intentional about documenting decisions, flagging risks early, and communicating progress — not just completing work in silence.

2. Industry Alignment & Professional Judgment

Job Advertisement Analysis: Junior Software Engineer – Mid-Size Product Company (Sri Lanka)

I reviewed a Junior Software Engineer vacancy posted by a mid-size product-based software company. The role required three core skills: proficiency in a modern backend framework (Spring Boot or Node.js), experience with RESTful API design, and the ability to work within an Agile/Scrum team.

- **Backend Framework (Node.js/Spring Boot):** I meet this partially. My hands-on experience building the PHP backend and JavaScript front-end logic during the Web Development project gives me a solid foundation in server-side web development. However, I have not worked with Spring Boot, and my Node.js exposure is limited to tutorial-level projects rather than production-grade applications. I would likely struggle with enterprise patterns such as dependency injection or connection pooling without further preparation.
 - **RESTful API Design:** I meet this skill reasonably well. Designing and consuming REST endpoints was a core part of integrating the front-end and back-end in the Web Development project. My weakness is in API security practices such as OAuth 2.0 and JWT implementation, which I have only read about rather than applied in a project.
 - **Agile/Scrum Teamwork:** I have practised Scrum ceremonies in both the Web Development module and my FYP, including sprint planning, retrospectives, and using GitHub Issues as a backlog. My struggle would be the velocity expected in a professional sprint — academic sprints allowed renegotiation; a professional sprint has a fixed client commitment that cannot be adjusted without a formal change request.
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Ethical Scenario: Critical Bug Near Deadline

If my Team Lead suggested we ignore a critical bug to avoid delaying delivery, I would not simply comply. My first action would be to assess the bug's impact: if it only affects a non-critical feature with a clear workaround, a documented and communicated deferral to the next sprint may be justifiable. However, if the bug creates a data integrity risk, a security vulnerability, or a failure in a core user journey, I would escalate the matter beyond the Team Lead — either to the Product Manager or, in a serious case, the client directly — and formally document my concern.

This decision reflects my belief that professional integrity is not negotiable under deadline pressure. Delivering a system with a known critical defect without the client's informed consent is dishonest, and if discovered post-release, it damages trust far more than a short delay ever could. It also potentially exposes the company to legal or reputational risk.

Do I have the confidence to act professionally under pressure? Honestly, partially. I believe I have the values and the judgment to know what the right action is. What I am still developing is the assertiveness to push back against a senior colleague firmly but respectfully, without causing unnecessary conflict. Situations like the Web Development stand-up where I raised a difficult issue are building that capacity — but I acknowledge it will be tested far more intensively in a real workplace.

3. My Immediate Upgrade Plan

The following three actions are specific, measurable, and directly tied to the gaps identified in this reflection:

- **Action 1 – Complete an API Security Mini-Project by June 2026:** I will build and deploy a small Node.js REST API implementing JWT authentication and basic rate-limiting, publish it to GitHub with a README, and have it reviewed by at least one peer. This directly addresses the API security gap identified in the job advertisement analysis. Success metric: a publicly accessible GitHub repository with commit history showing iterative development.
 - **Action 2 – Introduce Deadline Buffers Using the 1.5x Rule by April 2026:** For every remaining assignment and FYP deliverable this semester, I will estimate my work time, multiply it by 1.5, and set my personal internal deadline to that figure. I will log my estimates and actuals in a simple spreadsheet to measure the gap over the next eight weeks. This directly addresses my professional discipline weakness of underestimating task duration.
 - **Action 3 – Complete a Mock Technical Interview by August 2026:** I will schedule two structured mock technical interviews through SLIIT's career services unit or with a working professional in my network, targeting the junior web developer role profile. I will record each session with permission, identify at least three specific verbal communication weaknesses from the recording, and address them before the next session. This directly targets my Communication rating of 3/5 and my identified risk of under-communicating under pressure.
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